

KEY EVENTS

7TH–15TH CENTURY

■ **634–36CE** The Arab armies launch their campaigns of conquest, with decisive defeats of the armies of the Persian Sassanid and Christian Byzantine Empires.

■ **648CE** In possession of Egypt, the Arabs begin construction of a fleet of war galleys, making them a Mediterranean naval power.

■ **9th century CE** The Arab Abbasid caliphs, ruling from Baghdad, make Turkish slave soldiers the hub of their military forces.

■ **1071** Seljuk Turkish horsemen outmanoeuvre and destroy a Byzantine army at Manzikert.

■ **1095–1291** The Crusades ignite prolonged combat between Muslim and Christian forces in the eastern Mediterranean.

■ **1396** The Ottoman Turkish army of Sultan Bayezid shows its superiority to heavily armoured European knights at the battle of Nicopolis.

■ **1453** The Ottomans take Constantinople, using heavy cannon to batter the previously impregnable city walls.



▲ ARMoured WARRIOR

By the period of the Crusades (1099–1291), Muslim warriors were wearing mail and distinctive spiked helmets, such as the example shown here.

KEY DEVELOPMENT

ARAB AND TURKISH CONFLICT

From the 7th century CE onwards, Arab and Turkish armies dominated large areas of Asia, Africa, and Europe. These Muslim forces' military achievements were a combination of tactical subtlety, fighting spirit, and the skilled use of available weapons technology.

The founding of Islam by the prophet Muhammad, in Arabia in the early 7th century CE, had dramatic military consequences as well as religious significance. In the century from 634CE onwards, Muslim Arab armies embarked on a series of campaigns of conquest that swept east as far as Afghanistan and west to the Iberian peninsula.

At first, the Arab military forces depended on camels to carry foot soldiers and supplies. But they quickly proved adept at absorbing new technology and tactics from the states they defeated. Soon, cavalry was the outstanding feature of Arab armies – including both light mounted bowmen and heavier armoured cavalry with spears and lances. The craftsmen of the cities they captured, meanwhile, manufactured high-quality swords; “damascene” steel, from Damascus in Syria, for example, was renowned for its resilience and cutting edge. Not previously a seafaring people, after conquering the ports of Egypt and Palestine, the Arabs developed a navy using the expertise of shipbuilders and sailors. They also adopted siege machines and tactics from the conquered Sassanid Persian Empire, and the Byzantine Empire, which they did not conquer. Muslim states later efficiently adopted such advanced siege engines as the counterweight trebuchet from their Christian enemies.

TURKISH FORCES

The migratory Turkish peoples, who inhabited large areas of central Asia, became a source of military manpower for Arab states from the 9th century CE, employed as “Mamluks” (“slave soldiers”) – in effect an elite, professional standing army. By tradition, the Turks were central Asian horsemen, armed with composite bows and fighting as fast-moving light cavalry. But like the

Arabs, they proved adept at absorbing useful technology and tactics from settled civilizations. During the 10th century, they began to convert to Islam and some groups, such as the Ghaznavids and the Seljuks, carved out empires for themselves, as Arab power fragmented and declined. In 1071, combined Seljuk forces led by Alp Arslan inflicted a crushing defeat on a Byzantine army at Manzikert (in modern-day Turkey) – a heavy setback, from which the Byzantine Empire never fully recovered.

The Christian invasions of the eastern Mediterranean, known as the Crusades, brought various Muslim armies into combat with forces



“The Turks at a given signal rode about them like swarms of wasps, showering arrows upon them from all sides”

BYZANTINE HISTORIAN ANNA COMNENA, *THE ALEXIAD*, c.1140